

Formation music video, Beyoncé

(2016)

**AS Component 1:
Investigating the Media
A Level Component 1: Media
Products, Industries and Audiences**

**Focus area:
Media language
Representation
Media contexts**

PRODUCT CONTEXT

- *Formation*, lead single for the album *Lemonade*, was released the day before Beyoncé performed at the Super Bowl final in February 2016. The *Formation* music video, directed by Melina Matsoukas, was released with the song.
- This music video has won numerous awards including a Clio Award for Innovation and Creative Excellence in a Music Video at the 2016 awards, and has been nominated in the music video category at the 59th Grammy Awards.
- The video is set against the backdrop of the flooding in New Orleans following Hurricane Katrina and the associated racial tension in America, and also draws historical parallels with references to racism and slavery.

PART 1: STARTING POINTS – Media language

Historical context

Explore the flooding in New Orleans following **Hurricane Katrina** to place the video into this context. The **racial tensions** following the floods (easily accessible through Kanye West's comments about President George Bush at the time) offer the chance to consider the way in which Beyoncé is inviting audiences to interpret **historical circumstances**.

Consider how the combination of elements of media language influences meaning and intertextuality:

- The music video offers a wealth of (sometimes conflicting/contradictory) **messages** and possible meanings. Many of the references in the video require an awareness of **issues** and **events** (such as the flooding in New Orleans and racial tension in America).
- The video also requires a high level of media literacy to recognise and understand **intertextual references**, such as footage taken from a documentary about bounce called *That B.E.A.T.* and references to news footage of police brutality, such as the lone dancing boy.
- Consider the ways in which factors in the music video **contrast and conflict**, and whether this creates a confused meaning in audiences or offers a coherent **message**.
 - » The use of **costume** is interesting. Antebellum dresses which seem to reference slavery contrast heavily with **stereotypical** “pop” signifiers such as tight fitting/revealing costume in some of the dance sections.
 - » Similarly Beyoncé's **performance** shifts from moments of aggression such as obscene gestures with her fingers to more culturally recognisable dance routines that seem less loaded with political or social **messages**.
- This contrasting use of **signs** leads to possible readings/meaning of the video:
 - » Is it exploring **issues** of the Black experience in America? Is it a personal exploration of Beyoncé's life? Is it attempting to discuss issues of **gender** and **equality**? Is it possible for the video to be all of these things?

Consider the dynamic and historically relative nature of genre:

- Beyoncé as a performer has worked within